

How To BUILD A COMMUNITY And WHY It MATTERS

Building a community and keeping it thriving is certainly not a bed of roses. Janardan Revuru, Community Leader, JavaScript Meetup, talks from his experience the constant questions he receives and few important steps that many larger communities have followed



JANARDAN REVURU,
Community Leader,
JavaScript Meetup

The demand for communities is growing. Even if its start is small, the returns are quite compounding. I would compare it to an adventure in the deep woods. You can start with a lot of preparation but it's better to be prepared to face the unknown. Technology and tools still continue to evolve, so you cannot rely on them completely. On your journey, you will find other fellow travelers who support. Be ready to deal with surprises yourself.

Many times, people fall into the trap of thinking a community is needed for problems to be addressed, or for support that people need. Even if these reasons are correct, the main core to build a thriving community entirely depends on you as a leader. Once this is clear, it is good to know the common mental blocks for people to start or join a community.

Four blockers

Why. It is a major question that people come up with as they see it as a contribution with no returns.

Awareness. There are a lot of communities that need a supporting hand and the lack of awareness among people to hit in the right direction remains.

Where to start. There are many who do not know where to start, despite having inclining thoughts and awareness.

How to start. People are unsure of what role they can play and where their contributions can be helpful.

A straight answer to these blockers is knowing the wide range of valuable skills that can be gained from technology, communication, influence, strategic thinking, and so on. It will be helpful to start discussions with the organisers as volunteers, note down your purpose, explore opportunities, connect with fellow teammates, contribute, and grow in your community.

Five steps to start and build a community

1. Research for a common interest. The very first thing to do is research, which can be done in a day, week, or maximum a month, without much time being spent on it. Think of it as a need for a group to be formed—be it technical or non-technical. You can visit two places to figure out whether it would be valuable to start or not. Meetup.com, where there are many communities worldwide, not just limited to location or technology. The second